

fridayReview

THE HINDU

Theatre beyond borders
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The Queen and her City

Consecrated yesterday after a gap of 17 years, the Meenakshi-Sundareswarar Temple, built and expanded by successive dynasties, is one of India’s architectural marvels

T.S. Subramanian

goddess Meenakshi is revered by the people of Madurai as their queen (*Maduraiyin Rani* or *Arasi* in Tamil), but what draws thousands of devotees from across the world to the Meenakshi-Sundareswarar Temple each day is its audacious architecture. Far more than a place of worship, the sprawling complex is a marvel of sacred design. It boasts 14 gopurams, including four towering raja gopurams at its eastern, western, southern and northern entrances; gold-plated vimanas above the sanctums of Sundareswarar and Meenakshi; the famed Golden Lotus Tank; and a train of magnificent mandapams. Built of granite, these halls are grand edifices supported by massive pillars and adorned with life-size sculptures, intricate carvings, friezes, murals and, most importantly, inscriptions. Equally striking is the Indra Vimanam above Sundareswarar’s sanctum, held aloft by eight silver-coated elephant sculptures.

The Cholas, the Pandyas, the Vijayanagara rulers and the Nayaks contributed to transforming the Meenakshi-Sundareswarar Temple into the spectacular complex it is today. The Nayaks, who presided

over the temple’s final great phase of architectural expansion, left the most visible imprint. Viswanatha Nayak, the dynasty’s founder, Tirumalai Nayak and Rani Mangammal renovated and extended the temple, building several mandapams and introducing the distinctive composite pillars featuring *yalis* and human figures. The inscriptions recording the Cholas’ contributions, however, were lost during later Nayak-era renovations. Interestingly, epigraphist and scholar C. Santhalingam points out that “none of the Chola kings are known to have entered the temple, though the reason remains unknown. There was intense hostility between the Cholas and the Pandyas for about 200 years.”

One of the most striking features of the temple are its mandapams – Ashta Shakti, Meenakshi Nayak, Mudali Pillai, Unjal, Veerappa Nayak, Veera Vasantha Raya, Kalyana, 16-pillared, 1000-pillared, Sangathar, 63-Nayanmars, Nagara and Pudhu mandapams. Among these, the 1000-pillared and Pudhu Mandapams are renowned for their extraordinary architecture and breath-taking sculptures.

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A New Hope for Knee Osteoarthritis

India's DCGI Approved Stem Cell Therapy enters clinical practice first time in Tamil Nadu at Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals

UNDERSTANDING KNEE OSTEOARTHRITIS

Knee osteoarthritis (OA) is a common cause of pain, stiffness, reduced mobility and loss of function. While conventional treatments such as medication, physiotherapy, lifestyle modification and injections can provide relief, many patients with mild to moderate knee OA continue to face progressive joint damage.

WHEN KNEE PRESERVATION MATTERS

For advanced osteoarthritis, knee replacement remains an established and effective treatment. However, for patients with mild to moderate disease, the priority can be to preserve the natural knee and delay or avoid surgery wherever clinically appropriate.

At Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals, Dr. Deepak Kumar KS, Orthopedic Surgeon, Knee Replacement and Mako Stryker Expert, follows a knee-preservation-first approach. He evaluates every patient carefully and explores appropriate treatment options aimed at preserving the natural knee before considering replacement surgery.

REGENERATIVE THERAPY FOR SELECTED PATIENTS

In this pursuit of knee preservation, Dr. Deepak collaborated with Dr.Sathish Kumar Thangamani, MS(Ortho), D.Ortho., Dip (ABRM), Fellowship in Stem cell and Regenerative Medicine who is a Senior Assistant Professor @ Stanley Medical College and consultant at Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals to administer an innovative allogeneic bone marrow-derived mesenchymal stem cell therapy for carefully selected patients with knee osteoarthritis.

DCGI APPROVAL EXPANDS TREATMENT OPTIONS

With approval from the Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI), the availability of this regulated stem cell therapy represents an important development in regenerative medicine and expands treatment possibilities between conservative care and surgical intervention.

The therapy, manufactured by Stempeutics Research and made available by Cipla, is designed to leverage the anti-inflammatory, immunomodulatory and cartilage-protective potential of mesenchymal stem cells.

“As knee replacement specialists, we should not look at replacement as the first and only solution. Wherever clinically appropriate, I believe in exploring every possible avenue to preserve the patient’s natural knee. We are constantly looking at newer, scientifically supported treatment options that can potentially help patients maintain their joint and quality of life,”

- Dr. Deepak

Dr. Sathish says “the collaboration marks an important step in translating advances in regenerative medicine into clinical practice. We hope this approach will ultimately benefit many patients with knee osteoarthritis.” -



Dr.Deepak Kumar K S

MBBS, MS(Orthopedics), MCH(Ortho)
Chief Consultant - Orthopedic surgeon
Knee Replacement and Mako Stryker Expert

For patients with Grade II and III knee osteoarthritis, the availability of an approved regenerative therapy provides another potential option within the continuum of care. Individual treatment decisions, however, need to be based on the patient’s condition, disease severity and clinical assessment.

As knee osteoarthritis management evolves, the goal remains to provide patients with the right treatment at the right stage—while preserving the natural knee whenever clinically possible and using knee replacement when it is truly required.



For more details about the hospital visit www.drkmh.com

A Space Marketing Initiative



Karthik Bhatt

Pammal Sambanda Mudaliar's magnum opus *Nataka Medai Ninaivugal* is a fascinating study of Tamil theatre of the late 19th and early 20th centuries, as seen through the journey of the Suguna Vilasa Sabha. Written in excruciating detail in most parts, this work documents the important role played by the Sabha in creating a renaissance in theatre, nurturing several talents and troupes. Ahead of Sambanda Mudaliar's 62nd death anniversary on September 24, a look at the Suguna Vilasa Sabha's performances in Ceylon and how they inspired the formation of a theatre group in the island nation.

In 1909, Sambanda Mudaliar and a few friends went on a private tour to Ceylon and visited the Public Hall in Colombo. They made enquiries about staging performances there and the costs involved. In 1911, the Suguna Vilasa Sabha decided to venture into something it had not attempted before – taking their plays to Ceylon. Sambanda Mudaliar had to deal with multiple challenges in the preparations. One of them stemmed from within the Sabha itself, as a group of Telugu-speaking members protested against the inclusion of



Looking back (Clockwise from far left) Pammal Sambanda Mudaliar, the present building of the Suguna Vilasa Sabha and in the past; and V. Ramamurthi in the play 'Sikander', which was inaugurated as part of the revived Suguna Vilasa Sabha's Dasara celebrations in October 1958. PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES



Tamil theatre's Lankan voyage

How the plays by Pammal Sambanda Mudaliar's Suguna Vilasa Sabha found a dedicated audience across the Palk Strait

a junior artiste, who had just joined, at the expense of seniors. Another challenge was obtaining leave from work for artistes going on the tour, with Sambanda Mudaliar himself intervening on behalf of a few of them to resolve the matter. Costs, too, posed a challenge. This was, however, taken care of, since a drama contractor agreed to take responsibility of the entire production, paying the Sabha a lump sum of ₹ 2,500 towards the staging of five plays.

Finally, a nearly 50-member delegation travelled to Colombo, where it was welcomed by a group of prominent Tamils led by the eminent lawyer Sir A. Kanagasabai. Sambanda Mudaliar later wrote in his book *Nataka Medai Ninaivugal* that the tour drew large crowds and began with the staging of *Leelavathi Sulochana*. Among the audience

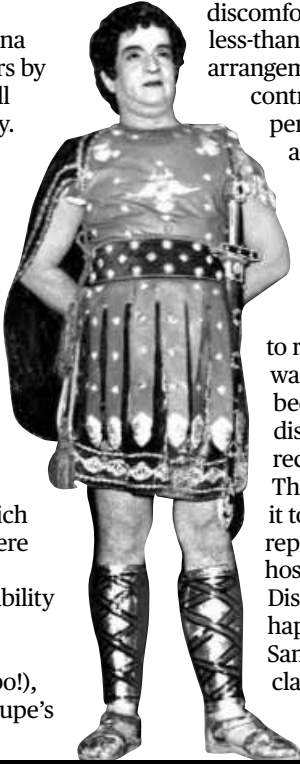
for the play was Warwick Major, who held a long lease on the Public Hall and regularly let it out for performances. This man would later etch himself in the history of Madras for giving it its first permanent cinema house, the Electric Theatre on Mount Road. Today, this building houses the Philatelic Bureau. The other plays staged included *Manohara*, *Galava Charithram*, *Amaladityan* and *Sarangadhara*. The Governor of Ceylon, Sir Henry Edward McCallum, presided over the performance of *Amaladityan* (an adaptation of *Hamlet*). Such was the success of the plays that Sir Kanagasabai requested Sambanda Mudaliar to stage another play in aid of the Governor's Tuberculosis Fund. The Sabha staged the comedy *Kaadhalar Kangal* and donated half the proceeds, net of expenses, to the fund.

Sambanda Mudaliar writes of

the warm hospitality accorded to the Suguna Vilasa Sabha members by people from across all sections of the society.

The Sabha embarked on its second visit to Ceylon in May 1913, this time including Jaffna in their itinerary. After staging five plays at Colombo, the troupe travelled to Jaffna, where things ran into rough weather. Sambanda Mudaliar took ill (which he attributes to a severe bout of indigestion brought on by his inability to refuse the grand hospitality at various gatherings in Colombo!), and adding to the troupe's

discomfort were the less-than-satisfactory arrangements made by the contractor for the performing venue as well as their stay. It was decided by the Suguna Vilasa Sabha committee to refund the advance taken and cancel the tour. The development led to rumours that the tour was being cancelled because the Sabha was dissatisfied with the reception it had received. The people of Jaffna took it to be an affront to their reputation as gracious hosts. Fortunately, the District Judge, MS Pinto happened to be Sambanda Mudaliar's classmate at Madras Presidency College.

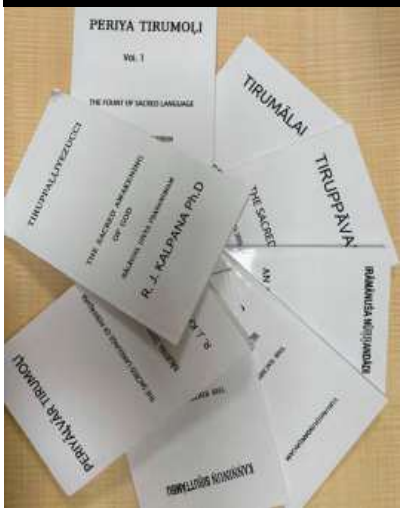


At his behest, a group of lawyers, took it upon themselves to ensure that the members were provided with better accommodation and facilities. The tour eventually continued and earned the sabha a surplus of ₹ 1,500, which went towards its building fund. As on its earlier visit, a benefit performance was staged at the request of a few prominent personalities, this time in aid of the Jaffna University.

During its silver jubilee year in 1916, the Suguna Vilasa Sabha undertook a final visit to Ceylon. According to Sambanda Mudaliar, it turned out to be a memorable occasion, since he was awarded the 'Rao Sahib' title as part of the king's birthday honours. It was announced as part of a scene in their popular play *Sabapathy*. It was greeted with thunderous applause.

According to Kalaiaarasu K. Sornalingam, a doyen of Tamil theatre in Ceylon, the Suguna Vilasa Sabha's tours marked a turning point in the history of theatre in the island nation. Inspired by its performances, he founded the Lanka Subodha Vilasa Sabha in 1913, which in turn led to the formation of other troupes in places such as Jaffna. Sornalingam considered Sambanda Mudaliar his guru, and the latter, too, recognised him as an artiste of repute in his book *Naan Kanda Naadaga Kalaignargal*.

Sambanda Mudaliar's influence as a theatre-personality truly transcended borders.



Azhwars' hymns in English

R.J. Kalpana's 27-book collection is a translation of the Naalaayira Divya Prabandham

T.R. Sudha

While there are some verses we grow up listening to without understanding their meaning, there are others that linger in our hearts due to their rhythm and melody. But we do not go beyond the sound to delve deeper into them. The *Naalaayira Divya Prabandham* is one such work, that is known for its lyrical richness and complex poetry.

Composed in Tamil by the 12 azhwars, in praise of lord Vishnu, these verses convey the myriad shades of bhakti, ranging from longing and joy to total surrender. Over the centuries, however, the hymns gradually began to lose their

prominence. It was through the relentless efforts of the ninth-century Vaishnavite scholar Nathamuni that they were recovered and organised into four major sections – *Mudhalaaiyiram* (containing 947 verses); *Periya Thirumozhi* with 1,134 verses; *Iyarpa* (with 817 verses); and *Tiruvoimozhi*, with 1,102 verses.

The history of these hymns points to the richness of the literary tradition. Yet, only some of the works are known today. For instance, Andal's *Tiruppavai* is familiar to many and is widely rendered and discussed during the Tamil month of Margazhi; while her *Nachiyar Thirumozhi* has travelled beyond the devotional space to become a recurring theme in classical dance productions. Thondaradipodi Azhwar's *Tiruppalliyehuchi* and Tirumangai Azhwar's *Tirunedundandagam* too have found artistic expressions. Apart from this, most of the Naalaayira Divya Prabandham remains unexplored.

It is here that author R.J. Kalpana's *Nalayira Divya Prabandham* series in English seeks to bridge the gap. Published by Pen & Ink Solutions, it brings together the complete works of the Azhwars, divided into separate volumes, with the Tamil hymns transliterated into English.

Each verse is accompanied by its English meaning, thus making the collection easier to follow for readers who may not be familiar with Tamil.

Also, breaking down the entire work into separate volumes encourages readers to explore the text at their own pace and gradually become familiar with their richness. Besides this, a list of divyadesams along with the corresponding pasurams and the verse numbers make it easy for readers to navigate to the relevant page and verse.

Another valuable addition is the table, displayed in the last few pages, carrying details of the hymns rendered by the respective Azhwars featured in the book.

"This work is the result of four years of study, reflection and perseverance. Along the way, I often paused to admire the remarkable spiritual depth of the Azhwars," says the author.

Rhythm meets technique

The recently held Smriti festival celebrated the artistry and beauty of footwork in Kathak

V.V. Ramani

Kathak is not often featured on Chennai performance platforms. To turn the spotlight on the dance form, Neha Banerjee (founder of Kathak Darpan Institute, Chennai) curates an annual event – Smriti – which features well-known Kathak artistes alongside young performers. A festival honouring the legacy of Pt. Birju Maharaj, this year's edition at Kalakshetra auditorium, featured an array of Kathak performances along with special sessions by Bharatnatyam gurus.

Neha performed on the inaugural day with Vishal Krishna from the Benares gharana. They started by paying obeisance to Shiva with the composition 'Nagendra haraya', choreographed as an interaction between the divine and the devotee.

They next explored the facets of layakari in Kathak. Neha's gentle footwork contrasted with Vishal's powerful tatkar, creating an interplay of the feminine and masculine energies. Neha began

with a teen tal composition of thaat and upaj in vilambit laya before moving on to a well-executed piece comprising seven and nine beats to a cycle of 16 beats.

Vishal portrayed the power of lightning and thunder through the bols 'Dhigi dhigi dhagha' with intricate footwork, which was the highlight of the piece. Finally, Kuchipudi met Kathak as Vishal danced on a brass plate. However, this segment didn't make much impact.

The evening also featured Kathak exponent Rajendra Gangani. Hailing from Jaipur gharana, his performance reiterated that beyond technique, and training, it is the passion and artistry that can elevate a performance.

A composition on Ganesha depicted the deity's form through an



(Left) Rajendra Gangani, and Neha Banerjee with Vishal Krishna. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

imaginative play of rhythm while another piece explored the contrast between stillness and movement. Pt. Rajendra is a master of Tribandhi, which is a composition woven in three segments. It involves intricate mathematical permutations of bols that arrive on the sam in a threefold pattern. The renowned dancer-guru displayed exceptional command over rhythm, speed and footwork, while also bringing to the fore the defining characteristics of the Jaipur gharana of Kathak. The performance left a lasting impression on the audience.

The musical ensemble – Vivek Misra on the tabla, Alka Gujar on the sitar and Jay Wardhan Dadich (vocals) – enriched the experience. Ashish Gangani joined the team on the Pakhawaj for Rajendra Gangani's presentation on Tribandhi.

An excerpt from Kalakshetra's thematic production 'Andal Charitam' was presented by the Kalakshetra ensemble as the concluding segment of the evening.

CULTUREBRIEFS



Three-day Kathakali festival

Kalakshetra Foundation presents 'Kadha Rasa Sangama' as part of the 17th annual Kathakali festival to be held from September 18 to 20, at Bharata Kalakshetra Auditorium, Kalakshetra Foundation. Performances and lecdems form part of the festival.

Schedule: Today, 5.45 p.m.: Sadanam Academy's 'Mandodari'. September 19, 6 p.m.: 'The Old Man and The Sea' by Kerala Kalamandalam. September 20, 5.45 p.m.: 'Rukmangatha Charitham' by Margi Theatre. The three-day festival will also feature lecture demonstrations (9 a.m. - 10.30 a.m.) and Kathakali presentations by the students of Kalakshetra Foundation (10.30 a.m.). The event in non-ticketed.



Landmark (Clockwise from left) The 1000-pillared mandapam; the sculptures of Viswanatha Nayak (left) and Perumal in the northern corridor of the Golden Lotus Tank with the southern raja gopuram in the background; a sculpture shows how people committing crimes were punished; the brass lamp gifted by Rous Peter at the entrance to the Veera Vasantharayar Mandapam; and a series of paintings displayed on the walls of the 1000-pillared hall PHOTOS COURTESY: THE GODDESS'S REALM



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The Ashta Shakti Mandapam, located on the eastern side, serves as the main entrance to the temple. Apart from featuring the sculptures of *dwarapalakis* and eight forms of Shakti, it also houses sculptures of Tirumalai Nayak and his two wives, Rudrapathi Ammal and Dhoni Ammal, who built the mandapam. According to Porchelvi Jeyaprakash, a scholar on the temple, the mandapam was built when the Shakti cult was dominant in Tamizhagam. “There is no temple, other than this one, which has a mandapam dedicated to Ashta Sakti”, she says.

As you walk out of the Mudali Pillai Mandapam, the Golden Lotus Tank (*Potramarai kulam*) confronts you. The tank is 200 ft long and 148 ft wide, with a total water spread area of 29,600 sq ft. Who excavated the tank is a mystery. Legend has it that, the tank served as the sacred site for many of Shiva’s 64 divine games known as *Tiruvilaiyadalgal*. He enacted these to bless his devotees, test their faith and establish righteousness. Though Meenakshi translates to the fish-eyed one, the temple tank has no fish, and it is attributed to Shiva’s boon to a devoted stork.

The pillars on the northern corridor have intricate stone carvings of Sangam-age poets, holding palm leaf manuscripts and a stylus. It also features sculptures of Viswanatha Nayak, and Perumal, who built the corridor.

On the western side of the tank is the Unjal Mandapam, built in 1653 by Chettiappa Nayak. Its ceiling and walls are decorated with exquisite murals, created during the rule of Rani Mangammal. Says S. Kannan, former associate professor of History, Annamalai University, Chidambaram, “the paintings are based on three themes: The wedding of Meenakshi and Sundareshwar witnessed by Rani Mangammal, her minister Ramappaier and grandson Vijayaranga Chokkanathar; Rani Mangammal receiving the royal sceptre from the goddess; and Parvati’s *dik vijayam*.

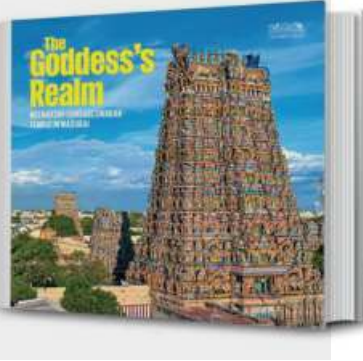
One then reaches the sanctum of Goddess Meenakshi, which, according to C. Santhalingam, was built in the 12th century CE during the reign of Kulasekhara Pandya. Until then, Meenakshi did not have a separate shrine. During the 7th century CE, when the famous Saivite saint Thirugunanasambandar visited and sang verses (*Tevaram*) praising the deity, Meenakshi did not have

The Queen and her City



An ode to a monument

The Hindu has recently launched a coffee-table book, *The Goddess's Realm: Meenakshi-Sundareshwar Temple in Madurai*, offering a comprehensive exploration of the many facets that contribute to the grandeur of this iconic shrine, recognised by the UNESCO. The front cover features a vibrant image of the upper tier of the rajagopuram. The 252-page volume is a carefully curated work that brings together the temple's history, stories associated with Goddess Meenakshi, and an account of the cultural festivals observed through the Tamil calendar, along with their significance. Striking photographs complement the narratives, capturing intricately carved pillars, towering gopurams and inscriptions etched on the walls, while highlighting the skill and artistry of generations of craftsmen. Bringing architecture, faith, history and living traditions together, the book offers a deeper understanding of the temple and its enduring place in Madurai’s cultural identity.



her own shrine. Instead, an idol of Angayarkanni (the one with fish-like eyes) was installed in the sanctum of Alavay Annal, as Sambandar called Chokkar or Shiva.

The temple is believed to be about 1,800 years old. While Sangam-age works such as *Madurai Kanchi* and *Purananooru*, as well as the post-Sangam *Paripadal*, refer to a Shiva temple in Madurai, none

mentions the present Meenakshi-Sundareshwar Temple. (The Sangam era was extant from third century BCE to third century CE). It is Sambandar, who, in his Madurai decads (Madurai *Padhigams*) describes the temple’s architectural layout, its location on the southern bank of the Vaigai river, and the long compound wall (*neel madhil*). He also talks about the Pandya king Ninnraseer Nedumaran, his queen



Mangayarkarasi and his minister Kulachirayar worshipping at the shrine of Alavay Annal. Tirunavukkarasar alias Appar, another revered Saivite saint and a contemporary of Sambandar, too has sung decads about this temple.

From a simple brick structure with a couple of towers in the 7th century AD, the Meenakshi-Sundareshwar temple has today metamorphosed into a massive temple complex over 15.37 acres. Besides the main sanctums, it also now has separate shrines for Mukkuruni Vinayagar, Nataraja (depicted in a rare posture

with his right leg raised and balancing on his left), Ellam Valla Siddhar, Bhikshatana, Saraswati and Subrahmanya.

To appreciate its grand architecture, mention should be made about the Kambathadi Mandapam, in front of Sundareshwar’s sanctum. Built by Nattukkottai Chettiars or Nagarathars in 1870, on its eight pillars are a large panel depicting the Sundareshwar-Meenakshi

marriage, with Vishnu, her brother, consecrating the wedding. “There are 25 sculptures of Shiva on these pillars representing his *anugraha*, *samhara* and *nritta* aspects. Their iconography is distinct from Nayak-period sculptures. The Kambathadi sculptures are heavily ornamented and characterised by cleft chins, razor-sharp shin bones and bulging kneecaps,” adds Prof. Kannan.

The temple had faced debilitating vicissitudes from three Delhi Sultanate invasions by Malik Kafur in 1311, Khusrro Khan in 1314 and Ulugh Khan in 1323. Parakrama Pandya, who built the west raja gopuram, valiantly fought the invaders but fled to Kalaaiyar Kovil during the third invasion. The invaders ransacked and looted the Madurai, Srirangam and Chidambaram temples. The Meenakshi-Sundareshwar temple was shut down for 48 years from 1323 to 1371.

The Vijayanagara army commander, Kumara Kampanna, arrived in Madurai in 1378 and drove out the invaders. Madurai was liberated and worship revived in the temple, whose mahakumbabishekam was performed yesterday after a gap of 17 years.

CALENDAR

Music and musings

Madhuradhwani has organised the following events at Arkay Convention Centre, Mylapore. Schedule: Today, 6.15 p.m.: Niranjana Srinivasan (vocal), Usha Rajagopalan (violin) and Ganapathyraman (mridangam). September 20, 6.15 p.m.: Release of books - *Thirai Isai Alaigal (2)*, to be launched by Bhoopathi Raju, the first copy of which will be received by Veeramani Raju, and *T.M.S.-The Voice That Moved Millions*. September 21 - 23, 6.15 p.m.: Discourse on Mahabharatham by Dr. Sudha Seshayyan. September 24, 6.15 p.m.: Tyagaraja Shishya Vaibhavam, a musical tribute to the composer-disciples of Tyagaraja by Vidya Kalyanaraman and Brindha Manickavasakan with R. Raghu on the violin, Neyveli Narayanan on the mridangam and S. Karthick on the ghatam.

Bharatanatyam solo

Natyanrangam, the dance wing of Narada Gana Sabha, will feature the following Bharatanatyam performances today at its venue. Details: 6 p.m.: Sandhya Udupa, disciple of Indira Kadambi, and 7.30 p.m.: Pavithera Lingendra (a student of Kalakshetra).

Title for musicians

Charubala Mohan Trust will honour senior musician Sugantha Kalamegham with the ‘Sangita Kala Praveena’ title and senior violinist Usha Rajagopalan with ‘Violin Nada Mani’ at a special event to be held on September 19 at 6 p.m. This will be followed by Sugandha Kalamegham’s vocal concert. Venue: Arkay Convention Centre, Mylapore.

Tribute concert

Hamsadhwani has organised a tribute concert dedicated to musicologist T.K. Govinda Rao on September 18, 6.05 p.m. Titled ‘Guru Vandanam’, it will feature Madurai T.N.S. Krishna’s vocal concert with L. Ramakrishnan on the violin and Srimushnam Raja Rao on the mridangam. Venue: Youth Hostel, Adyar.



Preserving a musical heritage

Beyond supporting performances, endowment concerts help preserve musical heritage and artistic legacies.

The Music Academy conducts several such programmes through the year, ranging from thematic concerts and lecture demonstrations to instrumental performances.

At a time when sustained support is vital to the preservation of the arts, CSR initiatives play an important role in enabling such programmes. Complementing Academy’s existing endowments, Karur Vysya Bank’s (KVB) CSR

initiative will support cultural projects such as ‘Presentation of Archival Vintage Concerts’, where music from another era finds renewed attention in a special presentation of archival concerts of S. Pinakapani.

It will be presented by the Malladi Brothers, Sreeramprasad and Ravikumar, on September 18 at 6 p.m. at The Music Academy.

This endowment has a distinctive premise each year. The music and scholarship of a vidwan of an earlier generation is revisited by a musician who either belongs to the lineage or has developed a deep

engagement with that particular tradition. The programme also draws attention to the extensive archival holdings of The Music Academy, where many hours of historic music await rediscovery. For students and rasikas, such presentations offer an opportunity to listen, study and understand the music of an earlier era.

KVB’s CSR initiative will also support ‘Sankirtana Saurabham: Learning compositions of Annamacharya’. The saint-poet’s sankirtanas will take centre stage at a two-day teaching workshop conducted by veteran musician Malladi Suribabu at the

Academy’s premises on September 18 and 19, from 10 a.m. to 12 noon.

Participants will learn Annamacharya compositions set to tune by stalwarts such as Pinakapani, Voleti Venkateswarulu, and Nedunuri Krishnamurthy, alongside compositions tuned by Malladi Suribabu himself. For students, the opportunity to learn these works directly from a musician steeped in that tradition lends the workshop a distinctive value.

This workshop is open to students and rasikas and a nominal registration fee is payable at the venue.

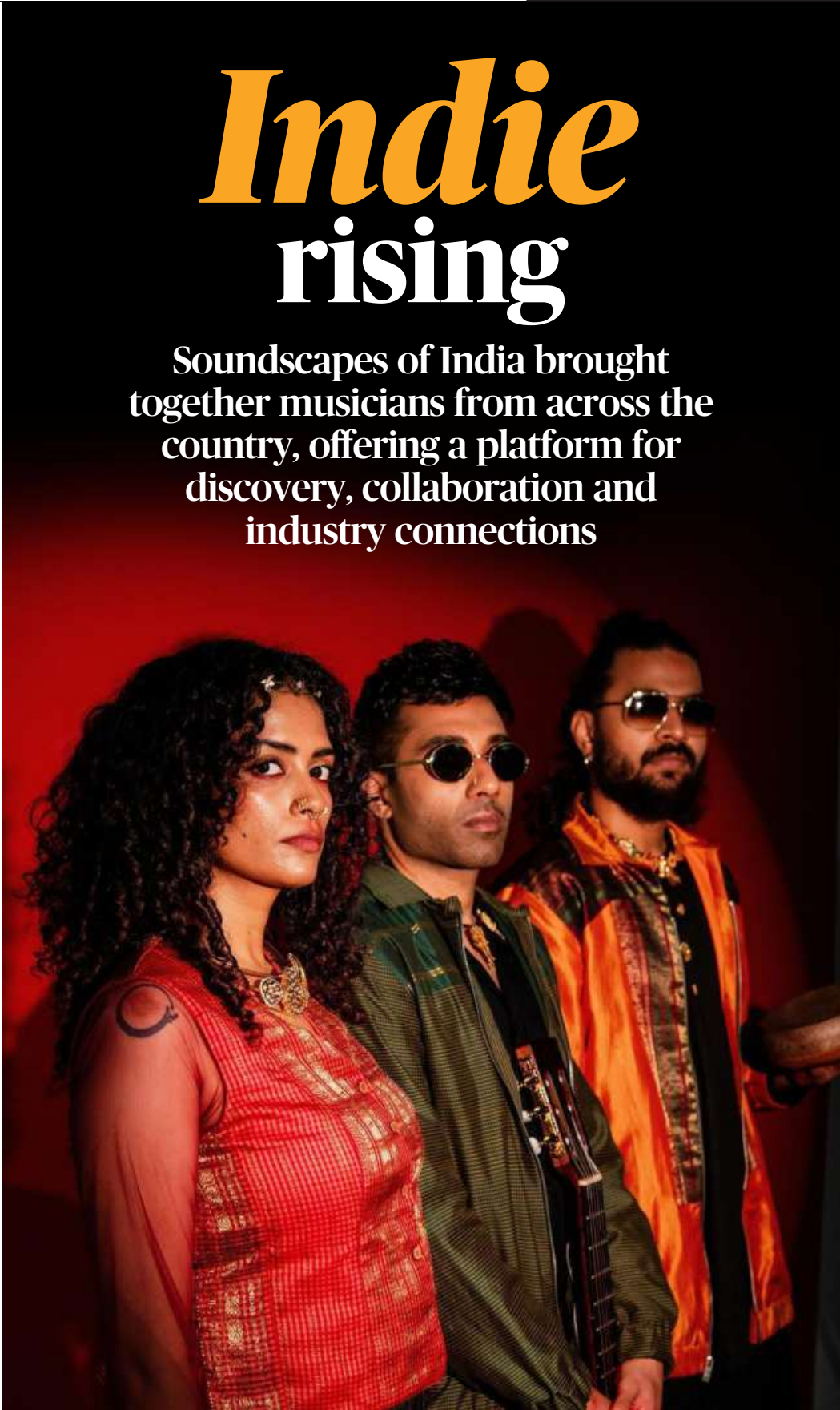
Narendra Kusnur

When keyboardist Abhijit Pohankar and his Global Varkari group presented Marathi abhangs for the Delhi crowd, they were aware that a language barrier might cloud audience grasp. So, Pohankar explained what abhangs are, the meaning of the songs and the ragas on which they are based. Harini Iyer, founder and vocalist of the Chennai-based Tamil Jazz Collective and Tsewang Nurboo, frontman of the Ladakh-based band Dashug, adopted their own methods to deepen the audience's appreciation.

Soundscapes of India – a three-day showcase, organised by the Indian Performing Right Society (IPRS) and curated by MusiConnect India – brought together sounds from across India. There was music from Meghalaya, Maharashtra, Ladakh, Chennai and beyond – some known names and some new. From fusion-rock and folk to Carnatic jazz and Hindustani classical jugalbandis, the range was diverse.

Music industry talent scouts and international promoters watched the performances closely, tasked with placing the musicians in festivals back home. They made notes on each artiste's musical and production skills besides showmanship. Additional marks were given to those with a distinct sound. Many were impressed.

Now in its third edition, Soundscapes of India, acts as a launchpad for many artistes, opening doors to larger festivals or solo gigs. Alongside veterans such as sitarist Purbayan Chatterjee, tabla exponent Anuradha Pal and guitarist Ravi Iyer, groups such as the Dobom Doji Collective from Arunachal Pradesh, Da-La-Riti from Meghalaya, Jatayu and Tamil Jazz Collective from Chennai, U.K.-based guitarist Kapil Seshasayee and Folk Foundation from Kolkata also took the stage. Overseas musicians included Ngartini Huang, an Indonesian who plays the traditional Chinese instrument guzheng, and



Egyptian singer-keyboardist Noha Fekry, who blends Arabic music with jazz.

With a surge in live independent or indie music in the past decade, musicians look at different avenues to get visibility. The festival route is a vital platform. These events focus on a specific theme – Jodhpur RIFF spotlights folk music, Mahindra Percussion

Festival on different styles of drumming, or Bengaluru Open Air, which is about hard rock and heavy metal. At times, there are multiple genres, such as Lollapalooza in Mumbai, Ziro Music Festival in Arunachal Pradesh or NH7 Weekender in Pune.

Some Indian acts have performed at international festivals too, examples being

Chennai-born, California-bred Sid Sriram at Coachella, kanjira exponent Selva Ganesh, who is part of several global ensembles, mridangist Viveick Rajagopalan's Ta Dhom Project at the prestigious WOMAD world music gathering, drummer Darshan Doshi at the Cape Town International Jazz Festival and Mumbai band Midhaven at the German metal

Fusion frontiers (Clockwise from left): Tamil Jazz Collective; Ladakh's first musical band - Dashug; Dobom Doji Collective from Arunachal Pradesh; Abhijit Pohankar of Global Varkari and kanjira exponent Selva Ganesh. PHOTOS: COURTESY: SHANTANU KRISHNAN, DASHUG AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



extravaganza Wacken Open Air.

India or abroad, festivals play a crucial role in building an artiste's fan base. While solo programmes often cater to those who are familiar with the music, a festival appearance draws a crowd that may be hearing a band for the first time. An example was the metal band, Bloodywood at Lollapalooza, earlier this year. Though it was an established band within the metal community, this show attracted those who had come to watch other acts or just to hang out. Some even became converts.

Thirty-five year old

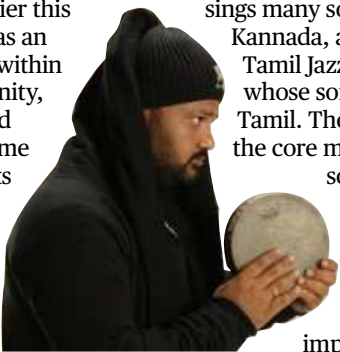
popular band in India, Delhi group Indian Ocean, is excited to perform at Lollapalooza early next year. Younger artistes such as the eclectic duo Ranj X Cliffr, and singers Anoushka Maskey and Shriya Rao also have slots at the festival.

Dobom Doji, a singer from Arunachal Pradesh who performed a folk-rock set at Soundscapes, says: "At a festival, people gather to experience different artistes and genres of music. Someone who has never heard my music before can discover it simply by being here."

Sahib Singh, guitarist of Chennai fusion bands – Jatayu and Tamil Jazz Collective – says, "festivals are a great space for crossovers and discovery. "The best ones, for me, are those that bring together completely different styles, sounds and genres without trying to fit everything into a fixed theme. It forces audiences to be open to the experience rather than deciding what they're going to expect."

There have also been instances when an artiste sings to an audience that is not familiar with a language. Examples are Bengaluru singer Varijashree Venugopal, who sings many songs in Kannada, and Harini of Tamil Jazz Collective, whose songs are in Tamil. They just explain the core meaning of the song before singing.

Harini says she is inspired by the American improvisational



CALENDAR

When beats shape melody

'Tala Pravaham — When Rhythm Becomes Melody', conceived by violin exponent Kumaresh, will be presented in Chennai on September 19 at 6 p.m. at Vani Mahal, T. Nagar. The specially-curated concert will feature seven compositions, one from each of the seven principal talas of Carnatic music. Anantha R. Krishnan (kanjira), Karthick (ghatam), Akshay Ganesh (violin) and Janya Abhishek Raghuram (vocal) will join Kumaresh for the Chennai edition.

Kumaresh explains that the project began as a quest to explore the Sapta Suladi talas and their five jathis, which further opens out into 35 distinct rhythmic structures. What he discovered was "transformative. Rhythm did not merely accompany melody, it began to shape and reveal it."



Debut

Adhithisriee P.J., disciple of Anuradha Vikranth, will be presenting her Bharatanatyam Rangapravesha on September 19, 6 p.m. at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Bengaluru.

Theatre in an intimate setting

Bharat Kalachar, in association with ABBAS Cultural, will stage *Idhu Nyayama Sir* on September 20, 6.30 p.m. at Bharat Kalachar, T. Nagar. The play will be presented for a limited audience in an intimate setting. Tickets on Bookmyshow.

Vocal concerts

Kedaram has organised the following concerts in memory of musician N.V. Subramaniam on September 22 at Ragasudha Hall, Luz, Mylapore. Concert schedule: 4 p.m.: Hrudayesh Ramakrishnan (vocal) accompanied by Bharghav Vignesh (violin) and Ajeet Sridhar (mridangam); 6 p.m.: Kalyanapuram Arvind (vocal) with L. Ramakrishnan (violin), B. Sivaraman (mridangam) and Nerkunam Sankar (kanjira).

Sri Sathguru Sangeetha Sabhha will feature Deepika Janakiraman's vocal concert on September 19, 6.15 p.m. at Sri Sath Sangam, 16, Anna Salai, Pammal. She will be accompanied by Palakkad Kailasapathy G. (violin), S. Govindarajan (mridangam) and G. Ganapathy (ghatam).

Chromepet Cultural Academy has organised S.M. Vilasini's vocal concert on September 19, 6.30 p.m. at the CCA hall. The accompanists are Subhashree Sivaramakrishna (violin), Ajeet Sridhar (mridangam) and Prashanth Mathru Bootham (kanjira).



Songs will live on Celine Dion on the opening night of her Paris 2026 shows; and (below) the audience. PHOTOS COURTESY: SINGER'S WEBSITE AND GETTY IMAGES



Paris sings with Celine

The singer's return became less a tale of recovery than one of resilience, as 30,000 fans helped carry the songs she could no longer sing alone

Rachel Rhine

It is strange that a song should come to mean something different from what its creator intended. When Jim Steinman wrote 'It's all coming back to me now' in the late 1980s, he was thinking of the scene in which Heathcliff opens Cathy's grave in *Wuthering Heights*. "I was trying to write a song about dead things coming to life," he said, emphasising the fear rather than the comfort in such a return. Yet the song came to be understood as a love ballad, and since Celine Dion first recorded it in 1996, she has spent a great deal of her career being misunderstood in the same way.

What exactly is an

audience asking for when it demands a singer's comeback? Nine million people signed up for the ballot, even though the venue had fewer than half a million seats, suggesting that many had already answered that question before fully considering what such a return might mean.

Celine started her 26-night residency at the Plénitude Arena in Nanterre, situated on the right bank of the Seine River, 47 minutes later than scheduled. It was her first full concert since March 2020 and her first performance of any duration since she announced in December 2022 that she had stiff-person syndrome. She opened with 'On ne change pas' (We don't change), accompanied only by a pianist and four

violinists, and the audience was on its feet before she had finished the first line.

However, she did not carry on for long. She broke down during the first number, lost her place in a lyric she had been singing for three decades, and held the microphone out to the audience. Thirty thousand people picked up the bridge and carried it to the end. It

A voice which has spent 30 years supporting everything is now being supported, and the fans who did it on Saturday will have to do it again and again as long as she keeps asking.

was not a recovery, and it never had to be. "I had promised myself not to cry," she told them later, before adding that the tears were the good kind.

A power ballad needs to be built-up. The verse begins gently, then the music gains momentum and finally, the chorus arrives in full force. It works only when a singer can sustain that effort. Stiff-person syndrome, which causes muscles to stiffen and resist movement, makes it especially demanding. After six years away from the stage, Celine was returning not just to perform but to test the limits of what her body could still do.

The production surrounding her was simpler than anyone had expected. There was no video screen,

singer, Bobby McFerrin, and the manner in which he uses his voice. She explains, "I am exploring how to use the voice as an instrument, not just for singing, but to emulate Nature and its sounds. McFerrin explored these aspects. This sentiment opened up many forms of music and languages, for me. I carry this forward in Tamil Jazz Collective and hope people will understand and enjoy our music even if they don't understand the language."

At times, festivals also promote a city's heritage and talent – Kala Ghoda Arts Festival in Mumbai and Bengaluru Habba. There's also the second edition of the Higher Ground festival in Bengaluru (to be held September 25 to 27). The event aims to bring together the city's independent music community, with genres such as rock, alternative, progressive, electronic and singer-songwriter sounds. "Besides established acts, there will be new musicians making their mark on the city's independent scene, and emerging artistes waiting to be discovered and heard," says Vishwas Karanth of Gigital India, which is curating the festival along with Dogmatix Events.

Conferences too are a part of festivals such as Soundscapes where a platform is created for musicians to interact with industry folks and event promoters to pitch their work, even if they're not performing.

Showcasing a state's culture also becomes a part of the event. For Dobom, "Every time I perform outside Arunachal Pradesh, I see it as an opportunity to also to represent the place I come from besides my music." Wherever Tsewang Nurboo performs, he loves to talk about Ladakh and its beauty. "It ignites an interest in our culture."

During a panel discussion, at Soundscapes, tabla exponent Bickram Ghosh stressed on the need for more curations and collaborations. As Bickram Ghosh noted, this is the era of collaborations, and each new artistic partnership has the potential to create fresh sounds and fresh audiences.

no procession of costumed performers, no elaborate stage architecture unfolding over the course of the evening. Behind her, a series of plain slabs created by stage designer, Willo Perron, opened and closed against a dark backdrop. A few visual flourishes had been carefully positioned: a pink feathered cape appeared when she sang the Catalani aria beneath falling snow, and later she bent down at the edge of the stage to reach those who had moved forward.

Though many do not realise, Celine occupies a larger place in Indian listening habits. Her songs have long been part of our everyday life, playing in homes after dinner, on late-night cab rides and at school annual day functions. For many young singers, 'Because you loved me' or 'My heart will go on' were among the first songs they performed in public. Over the years, her music has become woven into personal memories.

Celine has never presented this return as a recovery. The condition remains, and 10 of the 26 performances have already been moved to next May. "The path was rocky and the road longer than expected, but I managed to stay on it," she told the audience. It was a statement about perseverance, not about being cured. In 1989 Steinman got the essence of it right, because a voice which has spent 30 years supporting everything is now being supported, and the 30,000 people who did it on Saturday will have to do it again on Wednesday and again on Friday and again for as long as she keeps asking.